The Writer's Eye — Episode

Watched: _____
Where: _____
First time? ☐ yes ☐ rewatch

An episode has to work twice: as one unit, and as one link. Read it both ways.

SHOW	SEASON & EPISODE	EPISODE TITLE	WRITTEN BY
DIRECTED BY	**RUNTIME**	**WHERE IN THE SEASON**	**NETWORK / PLATFORM**

1 THE MACHINE

Before this episode — what makes a NEW episode of this show possible every week?

What does every episode of this show owe the viewer, no matter what?

What does this show do that no other show would do with the same premise?

2 WHAT JOB THIS EPISODE IS DOING

☐ pilot ☐ standalone / case of the week ☐ mythology advance ☐ bottle ☐ flashback / origin ☐ character showcase ☐ one-location farce ☐ table-setting
☐ penultimate escalation ☐ finale ☐ reset ☐ crossover ☐ format break ☐ holiday / detour ☐ premiere re-pilot

IF IT IS DOING SEVERAL — WHICH IS IT REALLY DOING?

If someone skipped this episode, what exactly would they miss?

Could this have been the cold open of the next one instead? Be honest.

3 THE STRANDS

A, B, C and the runner — and whether they are actually about the same thing

	WHOSE IT IS	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW IT RHYMES WITH A	RESOLVED / CARRIED
A story				
B story				
C story				
Runner / gag				

Where do the strands touch — do they collide, or just alternate?

Which strand is the episode *actually* about?

4 SHAPE & BREAKS

Streaming shows often have no act breaks at all. If this one does not, mark where the pressure rises and falls anyway — the shape is there whether or not anyone sold advertising against it.

COLD OPEN · ACT-OUTS · TAG — OR WHERE I WOULD HAVE PUT THEM

cold open — tag

☐ escalating farce ☐ slow burn ☐ parallel rhyme ☐ frame story ☐ real time ☐ flashback braid ☐ vignettes ☐ circular ☐ procedural A→Z
☐ two-hander ☐ ensemble split ☐ countdown

OR DESCRIBE THE SHAPE IN MY OWN WORDS

BREAK / TURN	≈ MIN	THE HOOK ON THE WAY OUT	DID IT EARN THE RETURN?

5 THE SERIALIZATION LEDGER

The honest question: did anything move, or was the week merely occupied?

THREAD	WHERE IT STOOD AT THE TOP	WHERE IT STANDS AT THE END	HOW FAR DID IT REALLY MOVE?	COULD IT HAVE WAITED?

6 CHARACTER, IN A SMALL UNIT

A week is not much room — which is what makes it a good test

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY WANTED THIS WEEK	WHAT IT COST THEM	CHANGED · OR SERIES-LOCKED

What is this show refusing to let change — and is that a strength or a cage?

Who got the least screen time, and did the episode miss them?

7 THE RULES OF THE SHOW

Every show teaches you its laws in the first ten minutes and then lives by them

	THE RULE	BROKEN THIS WEEK?	IF SO — DID BREAKING IT WORK?
Rule 1			
Rule 2			
Rule 3			

8 ECONOMY

Twenty-two minutes or fifty-eight, somebody fought over every one of them

What earned its minutes:

What I would cut, and what I would spend the time on instead:

9 IF I WERE IN THAT ROOM

Pitch the next episode in one line:

The episode I would write for this show — and which character it belongs to:

What would I put on the board for the end of this season?

10 CRAFT WORTH STEALING

WHAT THEY DID	HOW IT ACTUALLY WORKS	WHERE IT FITS IN SOMETHING OF MINE

VERDICT

☐ steal ☐ study ☐ avoid

The one thing I am taking into my own pages: